

Survey Wording Experiment Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 25-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	25-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	survey-wording-experiment

Big idea: Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

Overview

Students see how the act of measurement can shape human-science data.

Student Prompt

Inspect Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Survey Wording Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Measuring beliefs can alter the result.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Survey Wording Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can surveys measure beliefs objectively?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how measuring beliefs can alter the result.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two versions of the same question using 'support' versus 'allow'.
- A neutral, loaded, and leading survey item on the same issue.
- A class comparison chart showing how wording shifts results.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Half the class receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to support learning?"	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	The other half receives: "Should students be allowed to use AI to complete schoolwork?"	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Compare results.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Students redesign the question to reduce bias.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat class behaviour as universal human nature.
- Students may ignore ethical limits or context effects in human-subject inquiry.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Connects behaviour to method, context, incentives, and ethical constraints.
- Avoids overgeneralising from one small sample.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Ultimatum Game
- Conformity without Humiliation
- Replication Debate